valuable to its forefathers might be valuable to us today, but each generation is allowed to enquire into its own spiritual patrimony. The Vedas have a sanctified place in the Hindu consciousness, but the *Upanishad*s, the *Purana*s, the epics, and other works of spiritual and philosophical enquiry are also counted among our most basic scriptures. The three prasthanas or divisions of the Vedanta—the *Upanishad*s, the *Brahma Sutras* (555 aphoristic verses attributed to Badarayana and written down some time between 450 BCE and 200 CE, which summarise the spiritual and philosophical ideas in the *Upanishad*s) and the Bhagavad Gita—correspond roughly, according to Hindu philosophers, with the three stages of faith, knowledge and discipline. Each has value and each can be understood and practised alone or in combination with the others.

That said, as we have seen, Hindus, unlike Muslims and Christians, do not see their religious texts as claiming to embody the ultimate truth. Indeed, it would be a problem if they did, because then different texts would offer contradictory truths and men might be obliged to fight each other to demonstrate the superiority of their truth. Instead, a work of scripture is, to a Hindu, a means of self-realisation; the words, and the insights they contain, are devices through which a diligent Hindu approaches self-transformation. A religious text is a breach in the fog of ignorance that enshrouds the human mind. Allow its insights, the magic of its words, the music of its mantras, to penetrate through the fog, and a transformation might follow. The transformation is not merely in understanding the words of the text as in an Abrahamic holy book, but in opening the mind to new possibilities—including the possibility that the literal claims of the text might be false. The purpose of the religious text is to enter the mind of the reader and help constitute the self.

As Swami Vivekananda put it: ‘To the Westerners their religious books have been inspired, while with us our books have been expired; breath-like they came, the breath of God, out of the hearts of sages they sprang, the mantra-drashtas.’

Given this attitude to the Hindu holy texts, the Sanatana Dharma’s attitude to the Bible, the Torah or the Quran is the same. Hindus do not look for the literal meanings of these holy books; and since they do not